

Chitharal temple as it is today after restoration by the ASI.

The recovery of these lost chapters in India’s history began in the aftermath of what are now known as the four Anglo-Mysore Wars, fought over the last three decades of the eighteenth century between the East India Company (EICo) and its local Indian allies on the one side and the armies of Mysore on the other, led by two exceptional military commanders: the usurpers Hyder Ali Sultan and his son Tipu Sultan (whose last years are recounted in a later chapter). War by war, the EICo gained more and more territory, which then had to be surveyed to establish what revenue returns the Company could expect. Two surveyors were appointed, both Scots: one a surgeon turned botanist; the other a military engineer in the EICo’s Madras Army.

The first was Dr Francis Buchanan (whose name change to Hamilton in later years has caused much confusion among historians), the second Captain Colin Mackenzie. Both were instructed to make ‘a statistical account of the whole country’, but were given insufficient funding to do it properly – a handicap Mackenzie resolved by taking on as many assistants as he needed and paying them out of his own pocket. Thanks to the extensive records he left behind,